



Did you know...

When taking care of a sick baby it's important that you keep her fluids up, keep informed (know the signs and symptoms), let go of routines, don't overdress her, keep her room draft-free (but not too stuffy or warm), and remain calm so as not to alarm her.

Q What might I need to ask or tell the doctor?

To make the most out of the possibly limited time you have with your pediatrician, think about the information your doctor might need to know, and have questions ready. Taking a pad and pen means you can have questions written down so that you don't forget to ask anything, which is easily done when you're busy listening to what the doctor has to say.

Jot down any instructions or suggestions your doctor gives you for taking care of your baby at home. Be ready to give your doctor information about your baby's symptoms and when they started; about whether your baby has been feeding well and has had wet diapers; and about changes in your baby's temperature, and the time you checked her temperature. If you have given your baby any medicine, let your doctor know what you have given, how much, and when. Have your baby's immunization history ready.

Q What are the signs of a fever and how should I treat it?

If your baby looks unusually flushed, her skin is clammy and sweaty, and if her forehead, the back or her neck, or her tummy feel hot to touch, she may have a raised temperature that needs to be checked (see p.292). Your baby may also be cranky and drowsier than usual.

Most babies and infants work through a fever in a matter of days. If your doctor has seen your baby and is fine for her to be taken care of at home, continue to monitor her for as long as she isn't her normal self. Keep her fluid intake up and be on the lookout for signs of dehydration, such as fewer wet diapers than normal or a sunken fontanelle (see p.294). Once your baby starts to rally, don't launch right back into

normal activities—your little one may still be tired and need a bit of time to get back to her normal self. Having said that, babies often bounce back surprisingly quickly from minor illnesses. If at any point she deteriorates, perhaps becoming drowsier or clearly dehydrated, or if she develops a rash, or you just feel concerned, listen to your instincts and go right back to the doctor, or to the hospital if you are very worried.

HOW TO TREAT A FEVER

Follow these methods to help reduce your baby's temperature. You can also talk to your baby soothingly and reassure her that you're there to help.

» **While the first port of call** is to get medical advice when your young baby has a fever, you also need to make sure that she doesn't become dehydrated. A fever makes your baby sweat more, so she loses water as it evaporates on the skin. Keep topping up her fluids with frequent breast or formula feedings, and for formula-fed babies, give top-ups of water (fresh water that has been boiled and cooled).

» **Make sure** that your baby's environment isn't too hot—it should be around 64° F (18° C).

» **If your baby is distressed** by the fever, call your pediatrician to find out what dose of baby acetaminophen you can give her. The dosage will vary based on your baby's age and weight. Don't give babies younger than 6 months baby ibuprofen. And never give aspirin to babies or children. Baby acetaminophen and baby ibuprofen are available over the counter. Both come in liquid form with a dropper to make it easy to administer.

» **There is no need** to sponge your baby with lukewarm water, or remove layers of clothes—check, though, that your baby isn't uncomfortably hot with too many layers of clothing. You can strip her down to her diaper if she is incredibly hot.

Keep checking Take your baby's temperature at regular intervals and make a note of it and the time it was taken.

